

and helping those on low incomes with welfare benefits and a minimum wage. Economists suggest countries with a narrower range of incomes from rich to poor and less inequality not only have fewer social problems, but also more successful and stable economies. But in countries such as the US and UK, governments believe the economy does best if incomes are set by the markets. The gap between rich and poor is greater than elsewhere in the developed world, and is widening. Managers of large companies can earn many times more than their workers, and bankers make fortunes, while their cleaners may live in relative poverty. This inequality is justified by the “trickle down” theory: that bankers and businesspeople should be rewarded most because they create wealth that benefits us all.